

Attention is All You Need

(To Balance MMOs)



Making 7000 potions for the opportunity of getting to make more potions 4 hours later!

For folks who've played any games with me you'll be familiar with what's on my second monitor: OldSchool RuneScape. While SOME people may be shocked to know this, others with elite ball knowledge are aware of just how long my OSRS sessions can get. While this does reflect just how much I like the game, it doesn't seem to clear the stigma of "it's a boring game where all you do is click to make number go up". In order to clear my status of turbo-dented I'd like this blog to cover an interesting resource lever generally not covered in games: Attention.

Attention as a Resource

While I'm sure there's other games that use attention as a resource - I bet none are as deliberate as OSRS since it's a core component to all new content released nowadays. I think a simple example is woodcutting (which a surprising number of my friends have apparently done). While on the surface you just click a tree over and over there are a few variations of woodcutting which can either magnify or alleviate the dent in the head. For simplicity's sake I'll list a few below sorted by effort:

Method	XP/hr	GP/hr	Effort
Infected Roots	9k	~175k	Every 40 minutes
Redwoods	75k	~130k	Every 5 minutes
Forestry Events	~80k	~300k	Locking in every minute
Sulliusceps	97k	Variable	Constant Pathing and Tanking
1.5-tick Teaks	222k	0	Carpal Tunnel Hater (140+ APM)

In general the lazier a method is the worse XP you'll receive and in OSRS this is a deliberate choice. Since some folks play the game for a job while others just like an idle MMO this tuning allows players to gravitate towards methods that suit their playstyle. Of course this assumes that you have a membership and you've done lots of the initial content (eg. Unlocking Areas, Unlocking Skills, etc).

While this sounds great in a vacuum I'm sure some folks need to see what these rates look like in the context of a game. So I'll give two examples: An early game grind and a late game grind.

Early Game: Rat2RatComms

We'll need to build some more #lore for our hypothetical player to set the stage properly. Here is Rat2RatComms, a new player excited to read lots of wiki pages and even more excited to complete Dragon Slayer 1 because the quest description sounds like it'll be a proper challenge: *Prove yourself a true champion. Kill the mighty dragon Elvarg of Crandor and earn the right to buy and wear the Rune platebody.* Just the thought of flaunting the Rune Platebody has Rat2Rat raring to go!



This guy is so tuff 🤖

So what's stopping this lean, mean, machine from mowing down this quest? Well Rat2Rat doesn't actually have all the stats needed to complete Dragon Slayer 1 - he's missing 3 mandatory levels in Smithing (the anvil icon) and 6 optional levels in Prayer (the white diamond icon). Also since he REALLY wants the Rune Platebody he's going to have to get 84,500 gold coins (gp) to purchase the armor once the quest is complete.

Now we have Rat2Rat's 3 main goals that he'll work towards:

1. Level 34 Smithing
2. Level 37 Prayer
3. 84,500gp (let's just say he spent all of his savings on gacha)

The Grind

As an aside we'll also be taking some ✨liberties ✨ with F2P restrictions because the concept of "attention" being a tuneable parameter isn't fully realized in F2P worlds.

34 Smithing

Rat2Rat realizes that there's a few easy quests that can provide the Smithing XP needed to hit the goal of level 34. As a top tier bum Rat2Rat quickly pulls up the relevant guides and completes the Smithing "grind" in 15 minutes. However during this search he did find a few repeatable methods that he notes in the future:

- Blast Furnace Gold Smithing: 400k xp/hr, Very High APM
- Giant's Foundry: ~150k xp/hr, Medium APM
- Dart Tip Smithing: 15k-75k xp/hr, Low APM

37 Prayer

As previously established, Rat2Rat is really lazy and since there isn't a quest that can get him to 37 prayer he instead looks at the list of recommended methods:

- Chaos Altar: 500k xp/hr, Very High APM
- Reanimated Corpses: 140k xp/hr, Medium APM
- Lava Dragons: Variable xp/hr, Medium APM
- Blessed Bone Shard Mining: 15k xp/hr, Low APM

Rat2Rat immediately gravitates towards Blessed Bone Shard but quickly realizes that this requires a high level quest "Perilous Moons" to unlock. While it would be incredibly AFK (1 action per minute) the time it would take to unlock just isn't worth it for now. Since Rat2Rat also needs ~85k gp the final choice is to kill Lava Dragons and bury their bones.

84,500gp

Since Rat2Rat is doing most of this grind while reaching 37 Prayer the time spent is generally considered "zero-time" since he's not actively going out of his way to get the gold. Rat2Rat also knows that in case the Prayer grind finishes before he gets 85k gp there's a few methods that can top off the remaining currency needed:

- Eclipse Reds: 280k gp/hr, High APM
- High Alching valuable drops: Variable gp/hr, Medium APM
- Pickpocketing Varlamore Citizens: 100k-200k gp/hr, Low APM

In summary, Rat2Rat likely only needs an hour or two to hit all 3 goals and will likely gain some additional experience along the way. From there it's about another hour or two to complete the quest. For the hardest F2P quest that isn't bad at all! In fact a lot of these early levels can be easily skipped by quests and there is quite a literal step-by-step quest list to complete in order to get the levels and prerequisites for one of the most important quests: Song of the Elves.

Late Game Grind: ratratrat33

Ok honestly I'm getting kinda lazy writing this part of the blog so here's an example goal I could go for on my main:

EasyMediumHardElite

Skill requirements			Quest requirements	Additional requirements
50	90	52	Desert Treasure I	Started Fairytale II - Cure a Queen
60	45	91	Enlightened Journey	Started Sea Slug
42	82	81[nb]	The Hand in the Sand [1]	Reach 800,000 Nightmare Zone points (or 400,000 with the hard tier of the Combat Achievements)
94	50	50	Haunted Mine	Clear selection (3/3)
65	69	50	Legends' Quest	
50	59	85	Monkey Madness I	
107	1269+	1269+	Mourning's End Part II	
107	1269+	1269+	Rune Mysteries	
107	1269+	1269+	Tower of Life	
107	1269+	1269+	Watchtower	
Clear selection (17/21)			Clear selection (0/10)	

1. Ultimate Ironmen do not have to complete The Hand in the Sand.

Elite Ardougne swag to mog during every farm run

There's actually 3 major grinds I'd have to do but only 2 are based on my stats. More specifically:

- 77 Agility -> 85 Agility (+5 with buffs to hit 90)
- 77 Fishing -> 81 Fishing (This cannot be buffed up)
- Nightmare Zone Points

While I'm honestly unsure of how hard it is to finish the third task, I DO know that it's commonly known as the 20 minute AFK machine so it's probably the least annoying grind to do. Then moving on to the first two grinds they have the following grinding options:

Method	Skill	Hours	Effort
Sepulcher	Agility	25	Very High
1.5-tick Barbarian	Fishing	12	Extremely High
Prifddinas	Agility	40	Moderately High
Tempoross	Fishing	20	Medium

Agility Dungeon	Agility	150	Low (20min AFK)
Karambwans	Fishing	35	Low (10min AFK)

Personally I'll probably do fishing as side-monitor content and try to complete as many Agility related quests as possible since I have about 5 hours worth of XP on the table. I do need to complete the quests anyways so leaving that requirement for last is perfectly acceptable for me.

I'm also coming to the revelation that this might lowkey be an unreadable blog 🥲. Not because the content itself is bad but rather the audience might not be into MMO game design. So if this doesn't get enough engagement I SUPPOSE I'll have to write up a more flashy and shocking blog...

Until then,
ratratrat33 the ultimate AFKer